

ISRAEL SAYS IT TARGETED HEZBOLLAH POSITIONS, INFRASTRUCTURE IN RESPONSE TO CEASEFIRE VIOLATIONS

Israel strikes kill 47 in Lebanon; Tel Aviv says 4 soldiers dead in Hezbollah attack

Will extract ‘very heavy price’, says Netanyahu

Reuters
Jerusalem, June 19

ISRAEL AND Iran-backed Hezbollah agreed to a ceasefire on Friday, a US official said, after an escalation in hostilities in Lebanon sorely tested the US-Iranian interim deal to end the wider Middle East conflict.

A senior Israeli official and two Hezbollah sources confirmed the ceasefire to *Reuters*, which the US official said was due to begin at 4 pm. “If Hezbollah does not attack us, then for us it is not a time of war,” the Israeli official said.

Israeli forces would remain in southern Lebanon, the official added. Two Lebanese security sources said Israel carried out a dozen airstrikes in the first hour after the ceasefire came into effect, but none were recorded after 5 pm. An Israeli military official confirmed that there had been no strikes since 5 pm but denied that Israel had carried out a dozen strikes after 4 pm.

Israeli airstrikes had killed at least 47 people in Lebanon since midnight, the Lebanese health ministry reported. Israel reported four of its soldiers killed in south Lebanon in one of the deadliest Hezbollah attacks of the war.

The Israeli official said Israel had the freedom to act against emerging threats and threats to its forces and territory. Earlier, Israeli Prime Minister



Smoke billows from southern Lebanon following an Israeli strike, as seen from Marjayoun on Friday. REUTERS

Benjamin Netanyahu had vowed to “extract a very heavy price” from Hezbollah for the killing of the four soldiers.

Israeli officials have voiced anger at the US-Iran pact, saying it does not go far enough to address Israeli concerns over Iran’s nuclear programme.

Israel said it carried out strikes targeting Hezbollah operatives and infrastructure across several areas in response to repeated Hezbollah ceasefire violations.

Hezbollah denied it had violated the ceasefire, and accused Israel of repeatedly violating truce terms, including the terms of the US-Iran agreement. A statement from the group accused Israeli forces of carrying out attacks that killed civilians, destroying homes and infrastructure, and continuing its

ground incursions.

Heavy fighting overnight was concentrated in an area north of the Litani River known as Ali al-Taher hill - high ground strategically important to Hezbollah where Israeli forces had sought to advance, a senior Lebanese security source said.

Hezbollah said its fighters ambushed an Israeli force advancing near the hill, destroying three Merkava tanks with guided missiles and targeting troops with rocket and artillery fire. Hezbollah said it later attacked Israeli forces had sought to enter the area to retrieve casualties.

Israel has seized a self-declared security zone in the south, saying it aims to shield northern Israel from Hezbollah attack. Its forces have been razing villages in the south where they say Hezbollah has embedded itself.

Israel-Lebanon talks to be held in Washington next week, says US

Washington: The next round of Lebanese-Israeli talks will be held June 23–25 in Washington, the US State Department said on Friday following a call between US Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Lebanese president Joseph Aoun.

Rubio “reiterated the need to disarm” Hezbollah and reaffirmed US “support for the Government of Lebanon’s efforts for a fully sovereign Lebanese state...,” spokesperson Tommy Pigott said. **REUTERS**

Vance’s defence of Iran deal rests on vague and misleading claims

Zolan Kanno-Youngs, Rebecca F Elliott, & Erica L Green
Washington, June 19

VICE PRESIDENT JD Vance on Thursday defended the preliminary deal to stop the war with Iran as a “win for the American people.” But he relied in part on a string of aspirational, vague and misleading claims about the agreement.

Vance, speaking at the White House, sought to counter criticism that the deal would reward and embolden Iran without ensuring that the US achieved the main objectives laid out by President Donald Trump at the start of the fighting.

The agreement, which reopened the Strait of Hormuz, appeared to provide some economic relief to Americans on Thursday, as oil and gas prices dropped to levels not seen since the early days of the war.

Vance highlighted the development as he continued his increasingly prominent role as a defender of the deal.

“We have all the cards,” Vance said, adding, “If they change their behavior, big things are going to happen for Iran and for the world. If they don’t, no skin off our backs.”

But he sought to divert attention

from the text of the memorandum of understanding released by the two sides on Wednesday, which appeared to give Iran a number of immediate benefits.

Vance claimed that one immediate concession in the memorandum of understanding — lifting oil sanctions on Iran — was “not a new benefit” for the country. The claim ignores how the economic penalties in place before the war forced Iran to resort to desperate methods to sell oil. In the memorandum, Iran reiterated its long-standing commitment not to pursue a nuclear weapon, an assurance US and its allies have long regarded as largely meaningless.

Vance projected confidence that the final agreement would include terms upholding Trump’s goal of ensuring that Iran cannot possess nuclear weapons, and that Iran would not benefit from the changes promised in the memorandum if it does not comply with the US demands.

“They have promised not to enrich, they have promised they would allow inspectors in to destroy that highly enriched stockpile,” Vance said. “That’s why the deal contemplates a number of benefits if they do those things, but it doesn’t do anything if they don’t actually meet promises.”

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 20~06~2026

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All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination. There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

Congo Ebola outbreak worsens as deaths top 200

Associated Press
Dakar, June 19

THE EBOLA outbreak in Congo and Uganda has claimed more than 200 lives in its first month and is the worst known outbreak at this stage, with up to 35,000 suspected potential contacts, Africa’s Centres for Disease Control and Prevention said on Thursday.

With 894 confirmed cases so far, the current outbreak is three times worse than a previous outbreak in Uganda in 2000, which had 281 cases at the same point, said Dr. Wesam Mankoula, a medical epi-

demiologist at Africa CDC.

The latest number of cases is believed to be higher because the outbreak was confirmed on May 15, weeks after it was suspected to have begun. The number of cases has increased 38% since last week and is now in 32 health zones across eastern Congo, said Mankoula.

The outbreak is caused by the rare Bundibugyo virus, which has no approved vaccines or treatments and was not tested for in the early days. The more common Zaire virus, for which there is a vaccine, was responsible for most of Congo’s past 16 outbreaks of the disease.

SATURDAY, JUNE 20, 2026



The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

NEW DELHI, LATE CITY, 30 PAGES

₹7.00 (₹8 RAIPUR, ₹15 SRINAGAR) • www.indianexpress.com

VANCE, IRANIANS CALL OFF SWITZERLAND MEETING

Deal under strain: Iran suspends talks after Israel attacks Lebanon

Hezbollah-Israeli ceasefire after intense fighting, but Israel says its troops will stay

Aamer Madhani, Jamey Keaten & Samy Magdy
Zurich, Cairo, June 19

THE AMERICAN push to quickly begin high-stakes talks with Iran hit a snag Friday, just two days after the signing of an agreement that opens a two-month window for negotiations on Tehran's nuclear programme and returning oil traffic through the Strait of Hormuz to pre-war levels.

Iranian officials did not travel as planned to Switzerland, insisting that Israeli strikes on Iranian-backed Hezbollah militants in Lebanon must stop before the talks can

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E. EXPLAINED

Difficult talks ahead

The discussions in Switzerland, when they do happen, are expected to focus on Iran's nuclear programme. Tehran maintains it is peaceful, though it has highly enriched uranium that could be used to build multiple atomic bombs.



LNG carrier *Disha*, which was the first Indian vessel to cross the Strait of Hormuz after the US and Iran announced a deal, at Gujarat's Dahej port, Friday. Carrying Qatari LNG, the vessel had been stranded in the Persian Gulf for over three months amid the West Asia war. PTI

India's Russian oil imports at record high, set to remain core of crude diet

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, June 19

WITH INDIA stepping up its oil imports from Russia amid the loss of West Asian barrels due to supply disruption owing to the crisis in the region, crude imports from Moscow in June are expected to touch an all-time high, preliminary ship tracking data indicates.

Although the US has allowed its sanctions waiver on Russian oil purchases to lapse, at least for the time being, industry experts and insiders expect Russian crude to remain Indian refiners' mainstay in the foreseeable future.

So far in June, India's oil imports from Russia averaged at 2.6 million barrels per day (bpd), a whopping 53.5% of the

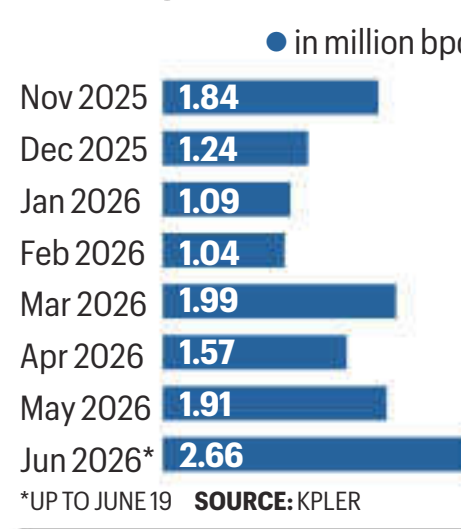
country's total crude imports for the period, as per vessel tracking data from commodity market analytics firm Kpler.

For the full month, Kpler expects Russian oil imports at over 2.35 million bpd, which would be the highest-ever. The previous monthly high was 2.2 million bpd in May 2023.

Sumit Ritolia, Manager,

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• Import of Russian oil over eight months



'LEAST RESTRICTIVE'

Delhi HC upholds Govt order blocking Telegram to secure NEET retest Sunday

Govt empowered to issue emergency blocking directions under IT Act: Court

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, June 19

UPHOLDING THE Centre's order directing temporary blocking of message application Telegram until June 22, ahead of the NEET-UG 2026 re-examination this Sunday, the Delhi High Court said Friday that the government is "empowered" to issue emergency blocking directions to not only individual users, but also platforms or applications like Telegram.

Dismissing Telegram's plea challenging the June 16 blocking order, Justice Tejas Karia held the government action to be proportionate and the "least

restrictive measure" for achieving the objective of potential misuse of the platform ahead of the NEET-UG retest on June 21, and preventing potential public order implications.

"The temporary blocking of Telegram under the Orders is operative only until 22.06.2026, while the disabling of the message-editing feature is confined to the period until 30.06.2026. The limited temporal scope of these measures demonstrates that they are narrowly tailored and confined to the period strictly necessary for securing the stated objective," Justice Karia said.

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Deal under strain

take place, according to three regional officials and a person familiar with the matter.

The situation was fluid as Israel and Hezbollah agreed Friday to renew their ceasefire, according to a US official and regional officials. It remains to be seen whether that could help put the US-Iran talks back on track.

In Washington, President Donald Trump lashed out once again in the midst of the intensified fighting in Lebanon and the stalled nuclear talks. “We didn’t meet out of desperation, Iran did,” Trump wrote in a social media post. “They are finished! We’ll play out the 60 days. They get no money, not ten cents!”

Trump’s vice president, JD Vance, had been prepared to make an overnight flight to meet with his Iranian counterparts at a mountainside resort in the tiny Swiss village of Obbürgen and begin the technical talks.

Vance’s staff and a small

group of journalists had gathered at Joint Base Andrews outside Washington in anticipation of the trip. Dozens of White House officials, advance staffers and more media were already in Switzerland. Then the trip was called off — abruptly and for the time being.

A White House statement said Vance, tapped by Trump to lead the negotiations, decided to postpone his travel. It made no mention of the escalating violence in Lebanon. “The logistics of these negotiations have never been simple or predictable,” the statement said.

But, according to officials, the Iranians made clear to the White House that they had balked at starting the talks with Vance because of the Israeli action in Lebanon.

The fighting had intensified with at least 18 killed by Israeli airstrikes, while four Israeli soldiers were killed in southern Lebanon, officials said.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Israel’s

military would stay in a “security zone” of southern Lebanon as long as “Israel’s security needs require it.”

Israel and Hezbollah are not parties to the US-Iran agreement. Iran insists Israel must withdraw from the large swath of southern Lebanon it is occupying, but the wording of the interim deal does not explicitly require that and only ensures Lebanon’s “territorial integrity.”

Hours before postponing his trip, Vance gave some indication of the state of flux when he told reporters at a White House briefing that he was uncertain if the talks were going to happen this weekend. “We think these technical negotiations start sometime this weekend,”

Vance said. “That’s still the plan. But that could change.”

Soon after Vance spoke to reporters, Iran’s supreme leader, Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, endorsed direct negotiations with the United States. His terse statement, read by state media, appeared to signal to the Islamic Republic’s leadership that it could move forward with a first round of talks.

“It is obvious that the face-to-face negotiations that will be held in the future will not mean accepting the enemy’s opinion,” Khamenei said. The messaging seemed to give Khamenei, who was badly wounded in the US strike on February 28 that killed his father, some maneuverability.

Vance was initially expected to go to Switzerland to sign the agreement at a formal ceremony. Instead, Trump signed the document Wednesday during a glitzy dinner at the Palace of Versailles with French President Emmanuel Macron. Iran’s president, Masoud Pezeshkian, separately signed the agreement.

It says Iran’s stockpile of highly enriched uranium, which is believed to be buried under rubble left by US military strikes last year targeting Tehran’s key nuclear sites, must at minimum be diluted under international supervision. It also says Iran shall not procure or develop nuclear weapons, a commitment Tehran has made previously. Other commitments remain to be worked out.

— ASSOCIATED PRESS

HC on Telegram ban

The High Court also took into consideration the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology’s June 16 and June 18 orders that entity-specific actions, including reporting and removal of channels, groups, bots and accounts were “repeatedly found to be ineffective and inadequate”.

Weighing the blocking action through the lens of whether the objective to prevent misuse of the platform outweighed the ability of 150 million users in India to access the platform for lawful purposes, Justice Karia held it to be a proportionate measure, taking into account the platform’s unique architecture, which made it susceptible to platforming widespread dissemination of misinformation.

The temporary blocking order, issued by MeitY on June 16, and also confirmed by a review committee on June 18, was in exercise of the government’s powers under the Information Technology (IT) Act section 69A and its associated Rules.

IT Act Section 69A empowers the government to block access to “information” through any “computer resource” as an emergency measure, say if sovereignty and integrity of a country is threatened.

While Telegram had argued that such power can be exercised only with respect to “specific information” and cannot be construed to imply “a blanket restriction on an entire intermediary platform”, the High Court disagreed.

Justice Karia said the legislative intent was that “the expression “information” is required to be construed expansively”, and thus “there is no reason to exclude an application or platform from the ambit of the said expression”.

“An application or platform, in its ordinary and commonly understood sense, is a computer programme or software

designed to perform specified functions for an end user. In view of the express inclusion of “codes”, “computer programmes” and “software” within the definition of “information” under Section 2(1)(v) of the IT Act, there is no reason to exclude an application or platform from the ambit of the said expression,” he said.

Also relying on the definitions of “computer resource” and “computer” under the Act, he held that the same makes “it evident that information generated, transmitted, received, stored, or hosted through such software-based infrastructure falls within the ambit of Section 69A of the IT Act.”

“An application or platform performs logical, arithmetic and memory functions through electronic, magnetic or optical impulses, and includes input, output, processing, storage, computer software and communication facilities connected with a computer system or computer network. Accordingly, this Court is of the view that (the government) was empowered under Section 69A of the IT Act to issue directions for blocking public access to Telegram,” the High Court ruled.

It declined to interfere with the MeitY’s temporary blocking order on the ground that there was application of mind while taking the decision, even though Telegram had asserted otherwise, and due process was followed.

The High Court noted that the temporary blocking order disclosed reasons why it was taking this measure: to prevent “potential grave implications for public order in the country and for preventing the commission of cognisable offences arising from circulation of examination-related misinformation and purported examination papers on Telegram, particularly in light of prior incidents relating to NEET-UG 2026.”

Russia oil

Modelling and Refining at Kpler, said, “India’s imports remained strong through June, supported by continued discounts and steady refinery demand. Russian barrels remain competitive against global benchmarks. Regardless of whether the US waiver is extended, we expect India’s imports of Russian crude to

remain robust, even if not at record-high levels.”

India’s crude import strategy has shifted sharply since March 2026 as Strait of Hormuz disruptions tightened West Asian oil flows and increased freight risks. Russian crude remains the backbone of India’s import slate, while refiners have diversified aggressively toward North American and Venezuelan barrels to offset the drop in supplies from the Gulf.

About 40% of India’s crude imports usually came through the Strait of Hormuz, and most of that supply has effectively been offline due to the war. Hardly any oil has been imported from Iraq, India’s second-largest source of crude, for almost four months now. Iraq depends almost entirely on the Strait of Hormuz to export its oil.

Oil imports from the rest of West Asia have also fallen significantly, although Saudi Arabia

and the UAE have been able to export oil to India as they have pipeline infrastructure to bypass the Strait of Hormuz for some of their oil output.

Although an interim pact has been inked between the US and Iran – it could bring back the West Asian oil barrels – and the US sanctions waiver on Russian oil imports has also expired, analysts expect India’s crude mix to remain broadly unchanged as supply security and economics

continue to favour Russian and non-Strait of Hormuz barrels. It is not clear yet if the US will extend the waiver further; there are indications that it may not do so given the expectation of Gulf oil barrels returning to the market.

Abu Dhabi-based energy analyst Natalia Katona said, “Even with the waiver expiring, I do not see a clear path to a dramatic reduction in Russian crude flows to India. First, the volumes are simply too large to

replace quickly. Second, the Middle Eastern bottleneck around the strait will probably take months to normalise fully. Third, the Asian view of Russian crude has changed: it is now increasingly treated as a reliable base-load supply source rather than an opportunistic discounted barrel.”

Moreover, the Iran deal is being seen as shaky and the market appears to be unwilling to fully write off the risks yet.

CRITICS SAY MANDATE WOULD UNDERMINE CONSUMER WELFARE

Govt digs in heels against pushback, no new petrol 2-wheelers from Apr '28

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, June 19

EVEN AS it has been facing pushback, the Delhi government has decided to go ahead with the proposed ban on the registration of new Internal Combustion Engine (ICE) two-wheelers from April 2028 under its new Electric Vehicle (EV) policy 2.0, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The Indian Express had reported on May 8 that the electrification mandate had drawn sharp opposition from manufacturers and other stakeholders, who had argued that there is a lack of alternatives for personal mobility for a large segment of the population that buys motorcycles.

Many even argued that India's still-import-dependent battery and rare-earth supply chains, heavily reliant on China, are not yet equipped to support a transition at this scale.

Top industry bodies, including the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM), had also written to the government that "a mandate prohibiting ICE vehicles, would be counter-productive, potentially undermining consumer welfare and broader economic stability".

The industry bodies, in the



The draft was made public in April. FILE

communication, also pointed out that "despite Rs 75,000+ crore investments... by domestic battery giants, the current technology is still lagging in terms of performance and safety standards with respect to Chinese cell manufacturers".

They had also questioned the net environmental benefit of EV adoption at current energy mix levels and pointed out that around 71% of India's electricity comes from coal-based power generation (fossil fuels).

The government had released the draft EV policy 2.0 for suggestions and feedback from the public on April 11.

As per the draft, only electric two-wheelers will be permitted for new registrations in the Capi-

tal from April 2028. On similar lines, CNG autos will be banned from January next year.

The policy is expected to be tabled at the Cabinet meeting in the coming week and be implemented from next month, after the current policy, which has been extended multiple times till June 30, expires. Once implemented, it will be valid till 2030.

The proposed two-wheeler electrification mandate and the subsidy on hybrid vehicles have become the most controversial aspects of the policy.

"The government has taken a call on a two-wheeler electrification mandate, but the subsidy on hybrid vehicles is still under consideration," a source said. Similar to the mandate for two-wheelers and three-wheelers, the policy also proposes mandates for schools buses, fleet aggregators and delivery service providers.

Experts argue that large-scale fleet transitions require these kinds of mandates. "Countries that have successfully accelerated EV adoption have gone beyond purchase incentives. While incentives can help kick-start electrification, large-scale fleet transition requires strong regulatory signals such as Zero-Emission Vehicle (ZEV) mandates or phasing out of ICE vehicles," says Amit Bhatt, Ma-

naging Director for India at International Council on Clean Transport (ICCT).

"These policies provide automakers with confidence that demand for EVs will be sustained over the long term, encouraging them to ramp up production, invest in innovation, and expand model offerings. Over time, this leads to economies of scale, lower costs, and greater consumer choice, creating a virtuous cycle for EV adoption," Bhatt argues.

Two-wheelers constitute about 67% of the city's total vehicle stock, making their electrification crucial for reducing emissions. Electric two-wheelers have accounted for more than 7% of two-wheeler registrations in the last two financial years. So, the government has also proposed major purchase incentives. Buyers purchasing an electric two-wheeler priced up to Rs 2.25 lakh (ex-showroom) will receive an incentive of Rs 10,000 per kWh, up to a maximum of Rs 30,000 in the first year after the date of notification. The incentive will be reduced yearly. In the second year, buyers will receive Rs 6,600 per kWh, capped at Rs 20,000, while in the third year, the incentive will drop to Rs 3,300 per kWh, up to a maximum of Rs 10,000.

No fuel without PUCC: Capital readies plan to beat pollution in winter

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 19

NO FUEL for vehicles without a valid Pollution Under Control Certificate (PUCC) at petrol pumps in Delhi from November 1 and doubled parking charges at authorised facilities: these measures are part of the 'Proactive Winter Air Quality Management Framework' notified by the Delhi government with an eye on curbing pollution in peak season.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced on Friday that the framework lays down a series of measures that may be implemented between November and February to tackle seasonal air pollution, including staggered office timings and limits on physical attendance at offices, and tighter controls on construction activities.

The entry of non-BS-VI commercial vehicles registered outside Delhi will be restricted from November 1 to January 31. Exemptions will be provided to CNG and electric vehicles,

emergency service vehicles, and those engaged in government work, according to a statement from the Chief Minister's Office.

Parking charges at authorised parking facilities will be doubled from November 1 to February 28. "If necessary, staggered office timings may be implemented and government and private offices may operate with up to 50% physical attendance," Gupta said.

Residents and stakeholders, the CM pointed out, were usually informed about restrictions and measures only after air quality deteriorated during winter or when the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) came into force.

"This often left citizens, industries, institutions and commercial establishments with insufficient time to prepare, leading to inconvenience. This year, the government has decided to change that approach. We have notified the framework as early as June for pollution control in winter," she said.

Right to walk on safe footpaths a fundamental right, says SC

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, June 19

THE SUPREME Court on Friday held that the right to walk on secured footpaths is a fundamental right and urged the government to bring a law that declares this right and recognises the duty of municipal authorities and local bodies to build, demarcate, and maintain necessary pedestrian infrastructure.

“The right to walk is a fundamental right under Part III of the Constitution... The fundamental right to walk will take within its sweep the right to demarcated footpaths. These rights are primary and shall have priority over movement by motorised

vehicles,” said the bench of Justices P S Narasimha and Atul S Chandurkar.

The court said that the fundamental right to walk on demarcated footpaths has a correlative duty. “If the road exists, there is a duty to ensure that there are demarcated... The duty bearers are the urban development authorities, municipal corporations, municipalities and even panchayats, who must endeavour to demarcate, construct, maintain, and safeguard footpaths and other necessary pedestrian infrastructure, as walking is integral to life,” the bench said.

It further added that “the violation of the right to walk on de-

marcated footpaths will entitle the citizens to invoke constitutional and legal remedies against duty bearers for restitution and compensation. This remedy is independent of the remedies that are available under the Motor Vehicles (MV) Act, 1988.” The judgment came in a motor accident claim case related to a five-year-old boy’s death. A man and his son were walking toward his school when a tanker hit the boy, crushing his waist and lower body later succumbing to the injuries.

On May 30, 2016, the Motor Accidents Claims Tribunal (MACT) granted compensation of Rs 7.82 lakh, with 6 per cent interest per annum. The Supreme

Court enhanced it to Rs 11,44,628, and directed that it be paid within two months.

The Supreme Court noted “there was neither a footpath nor a pedestrian crossing” on the stretch of road where the accident happened and added that such incidents “continue to occur... till we restructure our rights regime as regards access to roads and recognise their correlative duties.” “It is rather strange that we failed to focus on recognising and securing this ‘right to walk’. It may be because wheels eclipsed our imagination, and our municipal administration was busy creating roads that are suitable for motorised vehicles,” the court added.

The Editorial Page

SATURDAY, JUNE 20, 2026

US diktat on AI makes case for global regulation

THE US GOVERNMENT’S directive requiring Anthropic to suspend access for foreign nationals to its AI models, Fable 5 and Mythos 5, has sparked a wider debate over the development and deployment of artificial intelligence and raised concerns across the world. Calls for technological sovereignty are growing louder, with national worries increasing about the implications of a single government being able to restrict access to the most advanced AI systems without consultation or transparency. Equally pressing are concerns about the risks associated with deploying such frontier models in the absence of independent oversight and a robust global governance framework.

The demand for a credible and robust regulatory framework is also gaining momentum, with even industry leaders making the case for stronger oversight. A few days ago, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei argued that “it is time to go beyond transparency to more serious and binding regulation of AI”. While the current issue reportedly stems from concerns about the circumvention of existing safeguards, the manner in which the decision has unfolded raises deeper questions. As Anthropic itself noted, the directive “did not provide specific details of its national security concern”. The fundamental question is: Who gets to decide access to frontier AI models? Should such decisions rest with governments, which have previously used chip export controls to restrict access to critical AI hardware, or with executives of private companies, whose decisions may be shaped by commercial and strategic considerations? What is needed is a transparent framework built on clearly defined principles and procedures. In fact, even Amodei has argued that frontier models “should be required to go through technical testing and auditing, and their release should be blocked or reversed as a threat to public safety if they do not meet high standards of safety”. He recommended that testing be carried out “by a qualified third party”.

Given the transformative and borderless nature of AI, these complex issues cannot be resolved by any one country acting alone. They must be negotiated at the global level through a governance architecture built on broad consensus and inclusive participation. All stakeholders need a seat at the table. India, with one of the world’s largest AI user bases and vast amounts of data that contribute to the value and capabilities of global AI systems, is a critical stakeholder in this debate. It must play an active role in shaping the international regulatory framework that will govern AI’s future.

Government that swears by nari shakti keeps failing women



SHAMA MOHAMED

EQUALITY WAS one of the basic principles of India’s freedom movement. The country’s founding fathers strove for equality irrespective of religion, caste, or gender. They ensured that women got equal rights to vote, own property, and participate in public life. Independent India aspired to be a progressive nation that treated its women with dignity, respect, and justice. It is, therefore, disturbing that, as India approaches the 79th year of Independence, women’s safety remains in crisis. According to the Women, Peace and Security Index 2023, India ranks 131st out of 177 countries, placing it behind several of its regional peers. For a nation that prides itself on being a global power, this is a sobering reality.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has promised to implement the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, which seeks to increase women’s representation in legislatures. To fast-track it, the government introduced the 131st Amendment Bill, which couldn’t muster the required two-thirds majority. Today, the BJP seems to be using unfair means to break the TMC and the Shiv Sena to get that majority. A question must also be asked of the party whose leader has often used the “*Beti Bachao Beti Padhao*” slogan: What has it done for the security of women on the ground?

The case of Bilkis Bano offers a troubling answer. In August 2022, the 11 men convicted of gang-raping her during the 2002 Gujarat riots were released under a remission policy. Images of the convicts being garlanded upon release by some BJP members shocked the nation. The BJP MP from Dahod, Jaswantsinh Bhabhor, and his brother, the party’s MLA from Limkheda, Shaileshbhai Bhabhor, even shared the stage with Shailesh Chimanlal Bhatt, one of the 11 men convicted for gang-raping Bilkis Bano. All this gave the message that even in one of the country’s most notorious cases of sexual violence, justice appeared negotiable.

Similarly disturbing is the treatment of self-styled godman Asaram Bapu, who

is serving life sentences in two rape cases. He got parole recently and reportedly visited the Ram Mandir and delivered *satsangs* in Varanasi. What does this say about the government’s commitment to women?

Then there is Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh, convicted of rape and murder, who has been granted parole on numerous occasions since his conviction in 2017. Parole decisions ultimately require the involvement of state authorities. The frequency with which such relief has been granted has fuelled concerns that political considerations often outweigh sensitivity toward victims and their families.

In 2023, several friends from other countries called me to ask why PM Modi was not listening to India’s celebrated women wrestlers, including Olympic medallists, who had accused BJP MP and then Wrestling Federation of India chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh of sexual harassment. Instead of receiving swift justice, the athletes found themselves protesting on the streets of the national capital. The images of the wrestlers being detained by the police while the accused remained politically influential sparked outrage both within India and abroad.

The broader statistics paint an equally troubling picture. Crimes against women remain alarmingly high, with hundreds of thousands of cases registered annually. According to the National Crime Records Bureau, in 2023, 15,000 dowry cases were recorded, with 6,100 deaths — a 14 per cent increase from the previous year. Cases of crimes against women rose from 4.45 lakh in 2022 to 4.48 lakh in 2023.

In which civilised nation is this acceptable? In numerous cases of dowry deaths, domestic violence, sexual assault, and harassment, women continue to face harassment and conviction rates often remain low. It is time for society to show the BJP government the mirror and hold it accountable.

The writer is national spokesperson, Indian National Congress



ARYA ROY BARDHAN

India must not wait for the next Hormuz crisis

IRAN’S CLOSURE of the Strait of Hormuz disrupted a route carrying roughly one-fifth of global oil supplies. Between February 27 and its March 31 peak, Brent crude surged 63.3 per cent. Global natural-gas futures rose as much as 16.7 per cent. India imports more than 88 per cent of its crude oil requirements. After Trump and Iran confirmed the MoU to halt the war on all fronts, Brent prices hit a three-month low.

India’s dependence on the strait o was uneven yet extensive. Before the war, around 40 per cent of crude imports passed through it. The exposure was greater for gas. India imports approximately 60 per cent of the LPG it consumes, with 90 per cent of those imports travelling through Hormuz. So, over half of domestic consumption was stuck at the chokepoint. Similarly, Hormuz accounted for around 55-60 per cent of India’s LNG imports.

The blockade created a price shock and a supply shock. India’s crude imports fell 13 per cent between February and March, while inventories declined about 15 per cent after the war began. April crude-import volumes were 4.3 per cent lower year-on-year, but the amount paid for them surged 52.3 per cent. This captures the peculiar burden of an oil shock that leads to stagflation. LPG imports fell to nearly half their February level, while domestic LPG production declined around 10 per cent from its March peak. LNG imports contracted 29.6 per cent year-on-year in April. Substitution required longer routes and higher procurement costs.

April wholesale inflation rose to 8.3 per cent, with fuel-and-power inflation reaching 24.7 per cent and crude-petroleum inflation 88.1 per cent. The merchandise trade deficit widened from \$20.7 billion in March to \$28.38 billion in April. Consumer inflation remained relatively contained because retail petrol and diesel prices did not fully reflect the increase in crude costs. This insulation, however, transferred part of the burden from consumers to oil-marketing companies and the government.

The rupee weakened from roughly Rs 91 per dollar just before the war to a record low near Rs 97. Foreign-exchange reserves declined from a record \$728.5 billion on February 27 to \$681.6 billion by June 5, that is, a 6.4 per cent depletion. The crisis confronted the RBI with a policy dilemma. Raising interest rates to contain imported inflation would have weakened domestic demand and jeopardised India’s strong growth momentum. Defending the rupee through sustained dollar sales would have depleted foreign-exchange reserves. Yet inaction risked allowing higher energy, freight and input costs to spread across the economy.

A durable reopening of the strait relaxes these constraints. Lower crude prices reduce the import bill and inflationary pressures, support the rupee and give the RBI greater freedom for policy. But depleted inventories, replacement contracts, and delayed inflation pass-through will persist. Broader sourcing from Russia, the Americas and Africa can reduce dependence on any one route. Adopting renewable electricity, storage, electric mobility, and biofuels would reduce the economy’s petroleum intensity.

The writer is junior fellow, ORF

The broader statistics paint an equally troubling picture. Crimes against women remain alarmingly high, with hundreds of thousands of cases registered annually

The reopening will lower prices and restore supplies, but depleted inventories, replacement contracts, and delayed inflation pass-through will persist

The Ideas Page

SATURDAY, JUNE 20, 2026

Buffers built in past decade shielded economy from energy shock



ANIL BALUNI

AT THE start of 2026, the global economy faced its deepest and most perilous disruption in a generation. Yet, India stood as a defiant beacon of stability under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. At a time when the global economy is faltering, Modi has not only ensured that India remains the world's fastest-growing major economy with a GDP growth of 7.7 per cent, but has also positioned the country as a pivotal anchor of the global system.

This was the result of strategic policies implemented under the Modi government, which spent a decade building defensive buffers. It focused on accumulating foreign exchange reserves, providing the RBI with ammunition to stabilise the currency. It had also diversified its crude oil procurement channels, which helped lower its absolute dependence on West Asian supply routes.

The strategic vision extended into domestic infrastructure. From the outset, the Prime Minister prioritised developing piped natural gas infrastructure across Tier-I and Tier-II cities to secure energy supply and shield citizens from cooking-gas shortages. Now, this network is scaling into rural areas. Initiatives like the PM Surya Ghar Yojana, clean nuclear energy developments, and ethanol-blended petrol demonstrate that a visionary approach can create solutions to complex energy challenges and logistical bottlenecks.

The geopolitical crisis culminated in a total shutdown of the Strait of Hormuz, triggering what the IMF classified as the largest oil-supply shock ever recorded. On paper, no country appeared more structurally vulnerable to this energy shock than India, which relies on imports for nearly 90 per cent of its crude oil requirements. Furthermore, roughly 61 per cent of India's Liquefied Natural Gas is sourced directly from West Asia. Standard economic models dictated that a blockade would devastate India's fiscal health, spark hyperinflation in food supply chains, and flatten its growth trajectory.

Rather than succumbing to the crisis, India achieved a stunning real GDP growth rate of 7.7 percent in 2025-26 thanks to the leadership of PM Modi. This was the highest growth rate recorded by any major economy in the world during that period. While rival global economies decelerated under the weight of surging energy costs, India under PM Modi accelerated, refusing to stumble despite facing a direct hit to its core vulnerabilities.

A deeper look reveals a permanent upgrade to India's industrial engine. The manufacturing sector delivered spectacular double-digit growth. Simultaneously, India's focus on self-reliance manifested in its defence industry. The annual defence production had surged to an all-time high of Rs 1.78 lakh crore during 2025-26. Furthermore, the massive deployment of next-generation digital infrastructure over the past decade enabled targeted, swift policy responses. Through infrastructure spending and steady income growth, the domestic market deepened. When international trade networks seized up, India's massive domestic market stepped in. By maintaining a conservative monetary framework, the government ensured that the RBI retained the flexibility to intervene when it mattered most.

The global financial community took note of India's triumph. At the peak of the West Asia crisis, IMF Chief Economist Pierre-Olivier Gourinchas commended the country's performance, stating that India "has been doing very, very well". The World Bank's April 2026 India Development Update concluded that India "remains among the fastest-growing major economies in the world". World Bank President Ajay Banga said India "has demonstrated that it can show exceptional growth", pointing to its forex reserves, low domestic inflation, healthy banking sector, and a public debt structure denominated predominantly in its own rupee.

Domestically, this vitality was validated by real-time data. Rising GST collections provided a real-time indicator that the domestic economy was generating substantial internal commercial activity rather than simply surviving the external shock.

The crisis of 2026 put India to the ultimate test, and the nation answered with an acceleration rather than a stumble. While the government built the vital macroeconomic buffers, this "resilience dividend" ultimately belongs to the people of India — driven by the daily actions of farmers, entrepreneurs, and consumers. Through a powerful combination of visionary leadership and domestic resolve, India converted a global energy crisis into a definitive demonstration of its economic sovereignty.

The writer is Lok Sabha MP (Garhwal, Uttarakhand) and national media head, BJP



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA

3 indigenously built naval ships to be commissioned tomorrow

Dunagiri is stealth frigate, *Agray* anti-submarine warfare craft and *Sanshodhak* is survey vessel

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, June 19

THE INDIAN Navy will commission three indigenously built frontline platforms — *Dunagiri*, *Sanshodhak*, and *Agray* — in Kolkata on Sunday, and the ceremony will be presided over by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Dunagiri is an advanced stealth frigate, *Sanshodhak* is a survey vessel (large), and *Agray* is an anti-submarine warfare shallow water craft.

In a statement issued Friday, the Navy said the platforms represent key operational capabilities across maritime combat, hydrographic surveying, and anti-submarine warfare. They have



Dunagiri is equipped with advanced weapons and sensors, including BrahMos surface-to-surface missiles and the medium range surface-to-air missile system. PTI

been designed by the Indian Navy's Warship Design Bureau and constructed by Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers (GRSE), Kolkata.

"Together, they reflect the Navy's balanced approach to capability development, strengthening blue-water operations, enhancing maritime domain awareness, and securing coastal waters against evolving threats," it said.

Dunagiri, the fifth Project

17A stealth frigate, is equipped with advanced weapons and sensors, including BrahMos surface-to-surface missiles and the medium range surface-to-air missile system, significantly enhancing the Navy's combat capability.

Sanshodhak, the fourth survey vessel (large), is designed for coastal and deep-water hydrographic surveys and collection of oceanographic and geophysical data

for defence and civil applications, and is equipped with advanced survey systems including autonomous underwater vehicles and remotely operated vehicles.

Agray, the fourth of the *Arnala*-class anti-submarine warfare shallow water craft, is equipped with lightweight torpedoes, indigenous rocket launchers, and shallow-water sonar systems to detect and engage underwater threats in littoral waters.

According to the statement, the three platforms demonstrate the growing maturity of India's indigenous shipbuilding ecosystem, with indigenous content exceeding 75 per cent.

It added that their construction involved extensive participation by Indian industry, including more than 200 MSMEs, and generated substantial direct and indirect employment.

In a statement earlier in the day, the Prime Minister's Office said that these inductions will significantly bolster the nation's operational capabilities, enhance maritime domain awareness, and strengthen the security of our coastal waters against geopolitical threats.

Heatwaves leading to increased concentrations of ground-level ozone, aggravating health risks: Study

Amitabh Sinha
New Delhi, June 19

HEATWAVES ARE not just a direct threat to human health, they also drive up concentrations of ground-level ozone that sharply aggravate mortality risks, a new study by Indian researchers has shown. In 2024 alone, more than 830 deaths in India could be attributed to increased ozone concentrations caused by extreme heat, according to the study.

The study, 'Heatwaves trigger severe surface ozone pollution in India: Regional Hot-spots, Trends and Health Effects', has been published in *Clean Air*, a part of *Nature* stable of journals, and is the first of its kind attempt to assess the health impacts of increased levels of surface-level ozone concentrations due to heatwaves in India.

Ozone is naturally produced, and found, in the middle atmosphere, at an altitude between 15 km and 50 km from



People use a cloth to shield themselves from the scorching heat on a hot summer day, in Lucknow on Friday. ANI

the Earth's surface. This ozone protects the Earth from the harmful ultraviolet rays in the sunlight. It absorbs these rays, acting as a natural sunscreen for the Earth. But ozone close to the ground is an air pollutant. Surface-level ozone is not naturally produced, but is by-product of chemical reactions between other common air pollutants like nitrogen oxides (NOx) and volatile organic compounds

(VOCs) in the presence of sunlight. Heat has the effect of accelerating these reactions.

"Ozone concentrations of about 30 parts per billion (ppb) at the ground level is usually considered safe. In most parts of India, this background ozone concentration is around 50-55 ppb. This is particularly true of northwestern India and the Gangetic plains, which carries a very high pollution load. Dur-

ing heatwaves, the ozone concentration is driven up even higher," said Jayanarayanan Kuttipurath, an associate professor at the Centre for Ocean, River, Atmosphere and Land Sciences at IIT Kharagpur, who authored the study, along with Parambat Sangeetha of Kerala University of Fisheries and Ocean Studies, Kochi.

Exposure to ozone affects lungs and heart, and can lead to Chronic Obstructive Pulmonary Disease (COPD) and Ischemic Heart Disease (IHD), apart from cancer and diabetes. A large number of deaths, in tens of thousands every year, is already associated with ozone exposure. The State of Global Air report for 2025 had said there were about 234,000 COPD deaths in India in 2023 in which ozone exposure was the aggravating factor.

Heatwaves are now exacerbating the problem. The summer months in India are generally a relief from air pollution, but the rise in ozone con-

centrations could be adding a new threat.

"Under climate change scenarios, because of general increase in temperatures all across, more and more regions are likely to have high concentrations of ozone. The frequency and severity of heatwaves is expected to rise, and so would the threat from ozone exposure," Prof. Jayanarayanan said.

He said agencies like the India Meteorological Department (IMD), or the Central Pollution Control Bureau (CPCB), needed to extensively monitor the concentrations of ground-level ozone, as actively as they do for a number of other parameters, and include this information in their bulletins and alerts.

The increased levels of ozone caused by heatwaves persists for about three to four days on an average after the end of the heatwave, the study said based on their analysis of data over the last 21 years.

CLIMATE

The key hurdle to climate targets: Electrification

Electricity meets a small fraction of the world’s energy needs. And most of this electricity is from fossil fuels. A big shift to renewables is needed



AMITABH SINHA

THE MID-YEAR climate talks in Bonn, Germany, that ended this week failed to make much headway on any contentious issue, but did throw up one interesting proposal.

Turkey, which will host the year-ending climate conference COP31 this year, proposed that the world should aim to meet at least a third of its energy needs from electricity by 2035 to reduce emissions. As of now, only about 20% of the world’s final energy consumption is met through electricity.

Turkey has suggested that all countries agree to adopt this goal as one of the outcomes from the COP31 conference, which it is hosting together with Australia in the Turkish city of Antalya in November.

The electrification target, if agreed upon, would be one more addition to several other climate-related global goals that are already in place, the foremost being the temperature targets contained in the Paris Agreement. The 2015 Paris Agreement says the world must strive to limit the rise in global temperatures within 2 degrees Celsius, preferably 1.5 degrees Celsius, from pre-industrial times.

The COP (Conference of Parties) climate meetings that are held every year have yielded a few more of these targets — such as increasing the installed capacity of renewable energy, achieving a global net-zero emissions, mobilising climate finance.

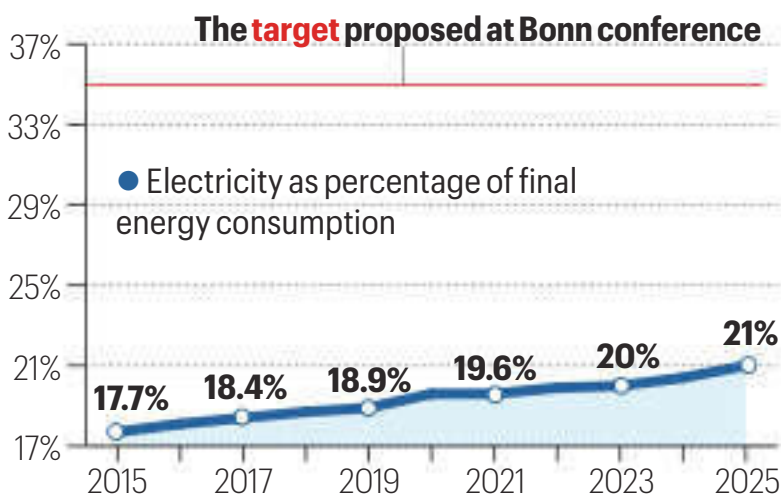
These are all aimed at reducing the world’s dependence on fossil fuels and speeding up the process of energy transition, which is the only effective long-term solution for climate change.

Electrification is at the heart of this energy transition. In fact, a complete energy transition, from fossil fuels such as oil, gas and coal, to cleaner sources such as wind and solar, is not even possible without full electrification. Tracking the electrification rate, therefore, is a good measure of the progress on energy transition. It also encapsulates the enormity of the climate challenge better than any other metric.

The electrification challenge

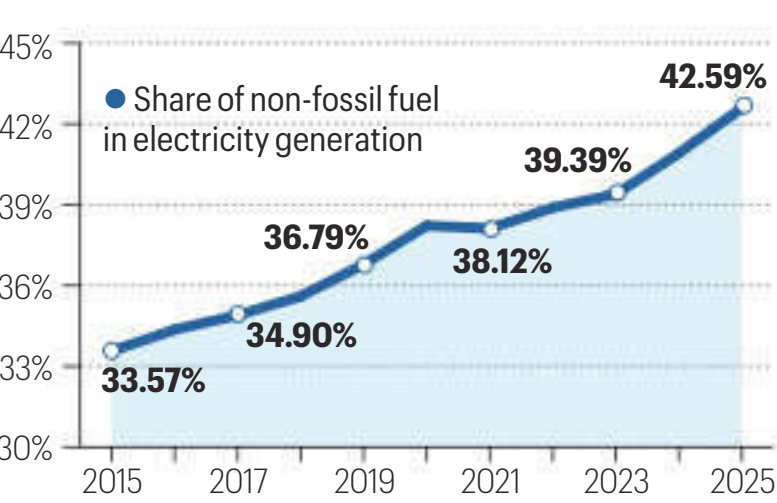
Climate change is the result of global warming which is caused by greenhouse gas emissions. Emissions come primarily from burning fossil fuels such as coal, oil, gas and wood, which are the main sources

LONG ROAD TO 35% ELECTRIFICATION TARGET



SOURCE: INTERNATIONAL ENERGY AGENCY

STEADY PROGRESS ON CLEAN POWER



A large number of sectors and processes are still difficult to electrify. FILE

of energy. A solution to the climate crisis, therefore, involves replacing these traditional sources of energy with newer and cleaner sources such as solar, wind, nuclear or hydropower, which have a much smaller carbon footprint. This is the great energy transition that the world has to go through to deal with the climate crisis.

It is not immediately obvious, but there is a fundamental difference between fossil fuels and the newer energy sources that have to replace them. Fossil fuels are direct sources of energy. They only require to be burnt to produce energy. Renewables, however, have to be converted into electricity before they can be put to use.

Replacing fossil fuels with the cleaner sources means that the only way energy would eventually be available would be in the form of electricity. That, in turns, means that every final use of energy would have to be electrified.

Considering how ubiquitous electricity has become, and the transformative impact it has had on the world in the last century and a half, it sometimes comes as a surprise that as of now, electricity meets only a small fraction of the world’s total energy needs. According to the International Energy Agency (IEA), electricity accounted for only 21% of the total final energy consumption (TFEC) in the year 2025. In India, the corresponding figure is about 23%, according to government data.

TFEC, or FEC, is a measure of energy that is ultimately used. It excludes all the energy that is consumed in producing, transforming or transporting energy itself. The coal that is burnt to produce electricity, or the energy used for refining petroleum, the diesel burnt for transporting fuel trucks, or the transmission and distribution losses in elec-

tricity, are not counted in FEC. All these are included in another metric called Total Primary Energy Supply, or TPES, which is a measure of total energy available for use.

Over the years, the amount of electricity being generated, globally, has increased from about 24 terrawatt-hours (TWh) in 2015 to over 32 TWh in 2025, a rise of nearly 33%. But the share of electricity in FEC has had a more modest rise during this period, from 17.7% in 2015 to 21% in 2025.

This is because a large number of sectors and processes are still difficult to electrify. Shipping and aviation, heavy-duty and long-haul trucks, many high-temperature processes in industries like iron and steel, cement, glass and ceramics, and even many residential needs like heating have remained largely unelectrified. This means these processes still cannot run on renewables.

Staring at a crisis

But this is not all. Electricity itself continues to be generated primarily by fossil fuels. In 2025, only about 42% of all the electricity in the world was generated by non-fossil fuel sources — renewables, hydro and nuclear — according to the IEA.

So, here is the stark reality. Only about 21% of total final energy consumption happens in the form of electricity. And only about 42% of electricity is generated through clean sources. That means that just a little over 8% of the total energy consumed in the world now is clean. After nearly three decades of efforts to promote cleaner fuels, through favourable policies, financial incentives, and technology innovation, more than 90% of the current global use of energy continues to depend on fossil fuels.

This is the enormity of the challenge that is not always evident in climate change

A reality check

Only about 20% of the world’s energy needs, or ‘final energy consumption’, is met through electricity.

Only around 42% of this electricity is generated through clean sources.

This means that just a little over 8% of the total energy consumed in the world now is clean.

or energy transition discussions.

The road ahead is not smooth. Renewables are expected to continue to expand at a fast rate, no doubt, but the share of electricity in FEC is not projected to increase dramatically. According to the latest estimates from IEA, non-fossils (renewables plus hydro and nuclear) are likely to begin producing nearly half of the world’s electricity by 2030. But the share of electricity in global FEC is expected to go up to only about 24% by 2030 from the current 21%.

An ambitious target

That is why Turkey’s proposal to make efforts to increase it to 35% by 2035 is an ambitious target. The proposal is based on a recent roadmap prepared by the International Renewable Energy Agency (IRENA).

IRENA says a 35% electrification rate by 2035 is the minimum needed to entertain any hopes of keeping the world on the 1.5-degrees Celsius pathway. But to achieve that level of electrification, an investment of about \$1.2 trillion needs to be pumped into electricity systems every year. A number of other things, including rapid expansion in renewables, and battery storage systems, also need to happen.

It is unclear how wars and geopolitical tensions would affect energy transition. Greater uncertainty in supplies of fossil fuels, and rising oil prices, may force countries to push renewables. But the economic fallout of these wars might squeeze out the budgets available for investing in new technologies and infrastructure. Countries might be tempted to use whatever energy source is easily available to them, regardless of its climate impact.

Govt asks ICANN to set up root server in India

New Delhi: The Centre has asked global internet body ICANN to set up root servers in India, a senior government official said on Friday. Speaking at the NIXI event, Ministry of Electronics and IT Secretary S Krishnan said there should be one root server in India to cater to the needs of the huge population of the country. “We have been pushing for locating a root server in India given the number of people who use the internet,” Krishnan said. PTI

India to assume vice-presidency of FATF for the first time

New Delhi: In a significant decision, India has been chosen for the incoming vice presidency of the Financial Action Task Force (FATF), the global money laundering and terror financing watchdog.

Vivek Aggarwal, a 1994-batch IAS officer and presently Secretary, Ministry of Culture, has been elected and appointed as the vice president of FATF from July 2026 to June 2027. This is the first time India will have a leadership position at the 40-member global body. The vice presidency for India also strengthens its chances for assuming the presidency role at next switch-over. ENS

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